These succulent mussels in their moat of gingery juices are terrific with a mound of fluffy rice on the side, but crusty bread mops up the broth just as nicely.

mussels in a ginger and chile broth

SERVES 2–4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 30–35 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

3lb (1.5 kg) mussels, in their shells, cleaned
1 stick (8 tbsp) butter
2 onions, finely chopped
2 bird's-eye red chiles, finely chopped
2in (5cm) fresh ginger, finely shredded
5 large garlic cloves, finely chopped
2 stalks lemongrass, split lengthwise and lightly bruised
½ cup ginger liqueur
1¾ cups fish stock
⅔ cup coconut milk
3 tbsp coconut cream
salt and freshly ground black pepper
juice of 1–2 limes, to taste
3 tbsp chopped fresh cilantro

1 Wash the mussels under cold running water. Give any open ones a firm tap against the counter top and discard any that don't close.

2 Melt the butter in a large pan over low heat and soften the onions, chiles, ginger, garlic, and lemongrass for 10 minutes without coloring.

3 Turn the heat up to high and add the ginger liqueur followed by the stock. Bring to a boil before adding the mussels. Cover the pan and cook for 5–7 minutes, until the mussel shells have opened. Discard the lemongrass along with any mussels that remain closed.

4 Pour in the coconut milk and cream, and bring to a boil. Season with salt and pepper, sharpen with lime juice, stir in the cilantro, and serve.